

In the Name of God, the Most Beneficent, the Most Merciful

Excellencies, Honorable Reverends, Distinguished Scholars, Ladies and Gentlemen

My warm greetings to all of you,

This webinar, which has been dedicated to examining the importance of morality in Imam Khomeini's thoughts and daily life, has once again provided us with a very good opportunity to talk about an important issue that today's human world is seriously in need of.

To begin with and at the outset I consider it obligatory to thank His Excellency Alireza Totonchian, the honorable Ambassador of the Islamic Republic of Iran in the Philippines, the authorities of the Government of the Philippines, the Church authorities of the Philippines, Dr. Morteza Sabouri, the cultural counselor of the Embassy of Iran, and all those brothers and sisters who have, through their endeavors, provided us with this opportunity, to have face-to-face conversations.

Keeping in view its significance and position in the teachings of all religions, the issue of ethics and morality has always been of great importance to religious scholars and thinkers. Moreover, the very fact that every school of thought claims to be concerned about moral issues and speaks about them, is because morality is rooted in man's innate nature.

Morality has been given various definitions.

At times it has been defined as a set of rules related to man's conduct and the values that are recognized as norms in a society.

- Sometimes as the theory of the ultimate goals of human behavior;
- Sometimes as practical attitudes towards others;
- At times as the doctrine of human happiness and the ways of achieving this goal;
- and sometimes, as a special set of rules to be followed as a code of conduct.

In short, morality refers to the science of goodness and badness, the principles of human behavior; and the theory that can ensure spreading goodness in society.

Of course, by referring to religious teachings, we find that; in the absence of morality, neither religion can be of any meaning to people nor would their worldly affairs be organized in the way it is supposed to be. Man deserves the name "human being" when he observes human morality, otherwise, he is a dangerous animal that

can destroy everything and sets fire to the entire world of being by using the rich human intelligence and can wage war to achieve his illegitimate material gains, or sow the seeds of division and hypocrisy and shed the blood of innocent people in order to sell destructive weapons!

Hence, the goal of ethics and morality is to lead man to perfection and true salvation and felicity, which is the main goal of the creation of the world and man. God is the greatest teacher of morality, the educator of the human soul, and the source of all virtues, and closeness to God is not possible except through adhering to divine morality. Undoubtedly, it is through the prevalence of moral virtues and the rule of religious ethics and morality that society can and would experience peace and mental health.

In numerous places in Islamic religious sources, morality has been referred to as the ultimate purpose of the appointment of divine prophets. The Noble Prophet of Islam, peace be upon him and his family, is quoted to have said: “إِنَّمَا بَعِثْتُ لَاتَمِّمَ مَكَارِمَ الْأَخْلَاقِ”, which means I was appointed and sent (as the Prophet) to complement morality and ethical values”. This word proves that the main purpose and objective behind the appointment of divine prophets was spreading and promoting moral issues.

The Prophet of Islam has also been quoted saying: “The best thing that will take my Ummah to heaven is God-wariness and good character.”

The late Imam Khomeini, who was basically an ethics-oriented jurist and a mystic and then a politician, has, unfortunately, come to be known more as a purely political figure as a result of which the other dimensions of the personality of this ascetic and God wary human being have been strongly overshadowed. This is in spite of the fact that before anything else, Imam Khomeini (ra) was an ethics-oriented personality and an ascetic human being.

The Imam’s lessons on ethics and morality in the Qum and Najaf seminaries - giving it a lofty position - and ensuring that it has profound effects on the addressees, clearly reflected on his profound spirituality as well as his high moral values.

It is to be noted that if Imam Khomeini had written the book “Islamic Government” in politics, he had also written several books such as Forty Hadith: An Exposition of Ethical and Mystical Traditions, Commentary on the Hadith ‘Aql va Jahl (Wisdom and Ignorance), Commentary on “Dua Sahar” (lit. Supplication at the time of Dawn), “Asrar al-Salat (The Secrets of Prayers), and “Adab al-Salat” (The disciplines of

Prayers), all of which were on ethical and moral issues and were, interestingly, written by him when he was aged 27 to 40 years old.

The Late Imam Khomeini believed that the Holy Quran is a book of humanization and that the divine prophets had been appointed by God Almighty to show man the way to being a true human being. He also regarded the teachings of the divine prophets to be the only cure for human sufferings and tried to make his audience realize the main cause of all the pains and sufferings they endure and the cure for them; and that it is this understanding that would make man get cured without being in need of any prescription and/or undergoing suffering.

Imam Khomeini (ra) first practiced what he preached to others, and it was for this very reason that he advised his son in these words: “My dear son, use the remaining part of your youth (for purifying yourself) because everything is lost in the old age, even paying attention to the Hereafter and God Almighty. One of the great temptations of Satan and the impulsive soul or the commanding ego is that it promises the young people of being able to rectify themselves in their old age so that the youth is lost through negligence; and he also promises old people of long life.” Elsewhere the Imam has said: O My son! What is condemned as the main source and foundation of wretchedness, cruelty and misery and destruction, is the love of the world and worldly materials, which is rooted in the love in one’s ego.”

Similarly, in a letter to his daughter in law, the late Imam Khomeini (ra) wrote:

“O My Daughter! If getting occupied in knowledge, even that of mysticism and monotheism is for the sake of accumulating technical terms - which it is - and only for the sake of learning a particular science, it does not lead the seeker closer to what should be the real objective, and rather distances him/her.”

He viewed morality from both individual and social aspects of it and believed that failure in any of them would lead to misguidance and going astray.

He advised the Hajj pilgrims not to fall prey to and in love with the appearance of the acts of worship, and know and understand the main purpose behind the exhausting acts of worship; in the absence of which all human efforts would go wasted. He defined the Hajj pilgrimage as follows:

“The philosophy behind the Hajj pilgrimage is to go and see the pain that other people go through; see the condition and the status of the poor of the world and try to share their pain and have sympathy for them.”

Elsewhere he said: “The purpose of all these rituals is to develop spirituality. The main purpose of the appointment of the divine prophets was to spread the divine rules and make them purify themselves the people (in the words of the Holy Quran “يُزَكِّيهِمْ وَيُعَلِّمُهُمُ الْكِتَابَ” (to purify them and to teach them the Book and wisdom). They were all appointed to introduce people to the source of divine revelation, to make them traverse the path to God Almighty, and to be guided to the right path.”

The political governance that Imam Khomeini called for is based on morality.

Today’s human society can very well sense and feel the existing immorality in individual, social and political behaviors. At the time when the coronavirus has spread throughout the world, human society is desperately in need of adhering to ethical and moral principles in order to be able to join hands and come up with a workable model of coexistence and philanthropy. The model in which sincerity, self-sacrifice, love, compassion, brotherhood, cooperation, and caring for others, especially the poor, the sick, and the downtrodden, etc., can save the planet from this pandemic disease and from the greed and oppression that is going on in the world.

In the end, I hope and pray that there will come a day when human society will follow the example of good human models so that security, peace, health, happiness, and felicity will spread throughout the entire world.

I look forward to such a day

Thank you for listening with patience